

ALASKA SEA GRANT

Annual Report

2023-2024



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THANK YOU TO ALL OUR PHOTOGRAPHERS

Front cover Dawn Montano/Alaska Sea Grant (Kachemak Bay). P 3 Alaska Sea Grant faculty and staff by Dave Partee/Alaska Sea Grant (Kachemak Bay). P 4 courtesy of Ginny Eckert. P 5 courtesy of Dawn Montano (Turnagain Arm). P 6 (top) courtesy of Jake Cohen (Kodiak Archipeligo), (middle and bottom) Julie Matweyou/Alaska Sea Grant (Kodiak). P 7 Biz Wallace/Alaska Sea Grant (top Homer, middle and bottom Whitter). P 8 courtesy of Allie Conrad (Bare Island). P 9 Jessica Whitney/University of Alaska Fairbanks (Juneau). P 10 (top and middle) Dawn Montano/Alaska Sea Grant (Sitka), (bottom) Molly Cain/Alaska Sea Grant (Sitka). P 11 (top and middle) courtesy of Zach Stamplis, (bottom) courtesy of NOAA Fisheries. P 12 Melissa Good/Alaska Sea Grant (Bethel). P 13 (top and middle) Ashley Dunker/Alaska Sea Grant (Nome), (bottom) Gay Sheffield/Alaska Sea Grant (Nome). P 14 (top) Ginny Eckert/Alaska Sea Grant (Haines), (middle) Gabe Dunham/Alaska Sea Grant (Bristol Bay), (bottom) image by Ralf Schick from Pixabay. P 15 (top) Sean Kelly/Alaska Sea Grant (Kwethluk), (bottom) Davin Holen/Alaska Sea Grant (Chevak). P 16 (top) Dawn Montano/Alaska Sea Grant (Sitka), (middle) Davin Holen/Alaska Sea Grant (Kodiak), Tav Ammu/Alaska Sea Grant (Cordova). P 17 courtesy of Carrie Stander (Valdez). P 18 (top) Leigh Lubin/Alaska Sea Grant (Valdez), (middle and bottom) Carrie Stander (Valdez). P 19 (top and middle) Tav Ammu/Alaska Sea Grant (Dillingham), (bottom) Melissa Good/Alaska Sea Grant. P 20 (top) Dawn Montano/Alaska Sea Grant, (middle and bottom) Molly Cain/Alaska Sea Grant. P 21 all photos courtesy of the fellow. P 22 (top) courtesy of Kit Cunningham, (bottom) courtesy of Nick Mills. P 23 all photos by Brooke Carney/Alaska Sea Grant (Anchorage). P 24 (left) courtesy of Dana Bloch (Southeast Alaska), (middle) courtesy of Noelle Helder (Beaufort Sea), (bottom) Jessica Whitney/University of Alaska Fairbanks (Kachemak Bay). P 25 all photos by Alaska Sea Grant. P 26 Dawn Montano/Alaska Sea Grant. Back cover Melissa Good/Alaska Sea Grant.



WHO WE ARE

Alaska Sea Grant is one of 34 Sea Grant programs supported by the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration in coastal and Great Lakes states that encourage the wise stewardship of our marine resources through research, education, outreach and technology transfer.

Alaska Sea Grant is a collaboration between NOAA and the University of Alaska Fairbanks and has been supporting healthy coastal resources, economies, and communities in Alaska for over 50 years. Our staff and Marine Advisory Program agents and specialists who live and work in Alaska's coastal communities carry out this mission through research, education, and outreach. ■



LETTER FROM THE DIRECTOR



Dear friends and partners,

As we close out another remarkable year at Alaska Sea Grant, I want to reflect on the significant achievements and progress we've made together. This has been a year of growth, collaboration, and innovation, and I'm incredibly proud of the hard work and dedication of our team, partners, and community members across the state and beyond.

One of the highlights was the record number of events we hosted, designed to facilitate learning and exchange among Alaskans and between Alaskans and colleagues from all over the world. From regional conferences to specialized workshops and training programs, these gatherings brought together a diverse range of experts, stakeholders, and community members to address challenges and opportunities facing Alaska's coastal communities and shared by colleagues. The enthusiasm and engagement at these events underscore the commitment we all share in sustaining Alaska's marine and coastal resources.

Our team grew with the addition of faculty and staff in Anchorage, Cordova, Juneau, and Kodiak. These talented individuals bring fresh perspectives, skills, and a passion for Alaska's marine environments. Their contributions will be essential as we address emerging issues and expand our programs. We're excited to have them onboard and look forward to the work we will accomplish together.

This year saw the expansion of our Alaska Sea Grant State Fellowship and Community-Engaged Fellowship programs. Through these initiatives, we are fostering the next generation of leaders committed to working with communities to address environmental and resource management challenges. These fellows are engaging with Alaskans, providing valuable insights and capacity to enhance local resilience in the face of change.

Several efforts supported greater community engagement and leadership. We piloted a program to provide seed grants to support enhanced community-academic partnerships. Through this initiative, we're supporting reciprocal, collaborative efforts between researchers and local communities and facilitating co-development of research questions. We provided seven awards to communities to help tackle marine debris. These projects are a testament to the power of grassroots efforts and the importance of community-driven solutions to environmental problems.

As we look forward to 2025, I am filled with hope and excitement for the continued growth of our programs and partnerships. I want to thank each of you for your unwavering support and commitment to the work we do. Together, we are making a lasting difference for Alaska's coastal communities and marine environments.

Sincerely,

Ginny L. Eckert, PhD
Alaska Sea Grant Director



HEALTHY COASTAL ECOSYSTEMS



ADDRESSING HARMFUL ALGAL BLOOMS AROUND KODIAK

Harmful algal blooms (HABs) have been a persistent issue off the Kodiak archipelago, with toxins from species such as *Alexandrium catenella* posing serious health risks. *Alexandrium* produces saxitoxin, a neurotoxin which can accumulate in shellfish, and can cause severe illness or death if consumed. The prevalence of these blooms is likely to increase with climate change, leaving rural communities at particularly high risk from HABs due to the importance of subsistence shellfish harvests and lack of access to emergency medical services.

To address this growing concern, the five-year project *Monitoring and Event Response for Harmful Algal Blooms* (MERHAB) has been launched. This federally funded initiative joins NOAA with Alaska Sea Grant, the University of Alaska, and the Kodiak Area Native Association (KANA).

Field work in 2024 included a 12-day science cruise, focusing on bays and nearshore waters around tribal villages. Jake Cohen, an Alaska Sea Grant State Fellow with KANA, is developing a long-term plan for ocean-acidification sampling. He emphasized the need for comprehensive environmental monitoring as communities adapt to climate change.

Mekia Bushell is a research fellow working with the NOAA National Centers for Coastal Ocean Science (NCCOS) Harmful Algal Bloom Forecasting Branch and is serving her appointment at the Kodiak Seafood and Marine Science Center (KSMSC). Alaska Sea Grant and NCCOS have a partnership investigating and mitigating the impacts of harmful algal blooms. Bushell is working on HAB forecasting and paralytic shellfish toxin monitoring capacities in Kodiak. She conducts weekly phytoplankton sampling and toxin tests across traditional harvesting sites, helping to map *Alexandrium* distributions in Chiniak Bay.

As Alaska's maritime environment transforms from the impacts of a changing climate, this collaboration will be vital to creating an equitable transition to sustainable and resilient coastal communities. ■



CLEAN HARBORS PROGRAM GROWS WITH HELP FROM STATE FELLOW

Whether working, playing, or traveling, time on the water is a way of life for many Alaskans. Small-boat harbors are vital, offering economic opportunities in tourism and shipping, supporting commercial and subsistence fishing, and serving as centers for cultural and recreational activities.

The Alaska Clean Harbors (ACH) program unites harbor managers, communities, and boaters to minimize environmental impacts and promote sustainable practices. This voluntary, non-regulatory program operates statewide, helping harbors reduce pollution and waste.

Alaska Sea Grant State Fellow Biz Wallace worked to coordinate the ACH program and expand its reach during her fellowship. She visited participating harbors this year to understand their challenges and offer solutions. She admired the dedication of harbor managers and communities to work alongside ACH to provide practical clean harbor solutions like pet waste stations and oil spill prevention signage.

Alaska now has three certified harbors—Juneau and Seward recertified in 2023 and Yakutat achieved certification in 2024. Valdez and Homer plan to recertify, while Dillingham, Dutch Harbor, Kodiak, and Whittier aim for first-time certification. To gain certification, facilities must complete a self-assessment and ACH checklist, including regulatory requirements and best practices for pollution prevention and waste reduction. ACH has introduced a new tiered certification plan—Silver, Gold, and Platinum—with requirements tailored to each harbor's resources.

Initiated in 2007 with support from the Alaska Department of Environmental Conservation and the Cook Inlet Regional Citizens' Advisory Council, ACH provides free technical assistance and resources to help harbor staff protect Alaska's waters. ■





SUSTAINABLE FISHERIES AND AQUACULTURE

SEAWEED GENETICS WORKSHOP DRAWS SCIENTISTS FROM ACROSS THE US

The Alaska Seaweed Genetics Workshop was held in Juneau to address information needs for preserving genetic diversity of seaweed as the kelp mariculture industry grows. Sponsored by Alaska Sea Grant and Alaska Fisheries Development Foundation with funding support from the Exxon Valdez Oil Spill Trustee Council's Mariculture Research and Restoration Consortium, the workshop brought together geneticists to synthesize current knowledge and guide policies regulating the broodstock of seaweed used to seed farms.

Presentations examined seaweed genetics around the country on topics including population genetics of kelp, selective kelp breeding, gametophyte cultivation and seedbanking, and heat stress tolerance of kelps in changing oceans. Discussions explored how this information may be applied in Alaska.

Research indicates that genetic diversity of seaweed has been significantly reduced as a result of excessive exploitation of wild habitat combined with vegetative farm expansion. As a precaution to protect genetic diversity in seaweed populations, the Alaska Department of Fish and Game created the 50-50 Rule for the State of Alaska. This regulation mandates that sorus tissue for mariculture operations must be collected from more than 50 parent individuals from within 50 kilometers of the outplanting site.

With these rules in place and only a few kelp hatcheries in the state, it can be temporally and economically costly to grow seaweed in Alaska. Alaska has received significant funding to grow from a \$1 million to a \$100 million industry in the next 20 years. The ideas exchanged during the workshop are helping researchers, farmers, and regulators address these important details while supporting the growing industry. ■





CONFERENCE ADDRESSES SHIFTING FISHERIES DISTRIBUTIONS

The 33rd Lowell Wakefield Fisheries Symposium was held in Sitka in April 2024. The three-day conference, hosted by Alaska Sea Grant, brought together more than 60 fishery researchers, managers, and community partners to explore political, jurisdictional, and management structures for adapting to environmental changes and shifting species distributions in high latitudes.

The symposium opened with keynote speaker Greta Pecl, professor of marine ecology at the University of Tasmania. Pecl highlighted key questions for climate-driven marine species redistribution in the context of fisheries, ecology, natural resource management, and social science. This was followed by research presentations and panel discussions on shifting fish and shellfish distributions, modeling, fisheries sustainability, adapting management structures, and the human dimensions of shifting resources.

The Wakefield Symposium series plays a vital role in advancing fisheries science in Alaska, addressing issues that are often unique to the region. It serves as a forum for exchanging information on biology, management, economics, and processing related to various fish species and complexes. Additionally, it provides an informal setting for scientists from high-latitude countries to discuss their research. For the 2024 gathering, participants traveled from across Alaska and other parts of the United States, as well as from Canada, Norway, and Australia, to share case studies and compare approaches.

Alaska Sea Grant has coordinated the Lowell Wakefield Fisheries Symposium series since 1982, in partnership with the Alaska Department of Fish and Game, NOAA Alaska Fisheries Science Center, North Pacific Fishery Management Council, and North Pacific Research Board. This year marked the return of the symposium series after a five-year hiatus. ■

NEW FISH AGING METHOD PROMISES FASTER RESULTS

Alaska Sea Grant-funded researchers are testing a new method to streamline the process of determining fish age using a method called Fourier transform near-infrared spectroscopy (FT-NIRS). Zach Stamplis, a University of Alaska Fairbanks graduate student, is working with Professor Franz Meuter on the project to develop a model that estimates the daily age of juvenile Pacific cod accurately and quickly.

Determining fish ages is crucial for researchers and resource managers to understand fish biology and inform management decisions. Fish ear bones, called otoliths, grow throughout a fish's life and display rings similar to tree rings, aiding in age determination. Juvenile otoliths can show daily growth increments, helping researchers calculate hatch dates, but the process typically used to analyze them is time-consuming.

To create an FT-NIRS calibration model, intact otoliths are scanned by a spectrometer. Near-infrared light reveals the otolith's chemical composition, allowing researchers to pair spectral data with daily ages obtained through traditional methods to build a model for estimating age using new spectroscopic scans.

The project is also testing the FT-NIRS calibration models on juvenile cod from other parts of the Gulf of Alaska to assess how environmental variables may affect the models. If successful, FT-NIRS could become a valuable tool for monitoring juvenile fish populations and assessing the impacts of climate change on Alaska's commercial fisheries. ■



RESILIENT COMMUNITIES AND ECONOMIES



CONFERENCE FOCUSES ON RAPID CHANGE IN WESTERN ALASKA

The 16th Western Alaska Interdisciplinary Science Conference took place in April 2024, hosted by Alaska Sea Grant and the University of Alaska Fairbanks Northwest Campus. The four-day event gathered over 130 scientists, specialists, and community members to discuss the theme “Western Alaska in transition.”

Every year, WAISC provides a forum for bringing urban and rural Alaskans together to a regional hub community to share knowledge and science across disciplinary and cultural boundaries. The event featured three plenary presentations. Nome’s Gail Smithhisler spoke on efforts to revitalize Indigenous languages, climate scientist Rick Thoman discussed research, monitoring and public service during a time of rapid change in Western Alaska, and Nome’s Chris Olanna, along with his father Ralph Olanna, provided perspectives on the integration of local and Indigenous Knowledge with technology to adapt to a changing environment.

Nearly 50 presentations were given on research topics that pertained to Western Alaska. Overarching themes included community science, ocean ecology, harmful algae, science in transition, education, and resource development.

“People commented that they enjoyed how locally focused the conference was,” said Tav Ammu, Alaska Sea Grant Marine Advisory Program agent for Dillingham and an organizer of the event. “Part of the reason we move WAISC around different parts of Western Alaska is to encourage the interactions between local scientists and researchers and those from other areas.”

A highlight was students from Nome-Beltz High School presenting original research on harmful algal blooms, finding detectable but safe levels in saffron cod, raising questions about winter ecosystem changes due to warming waters. ■





ESTABLISHING COMMUNITY PARTNERSHIP DEVELOPMENT GRANTS

Alaska Sea Grant is committing more than \$90,000 to fund four new projects supporting the development of community-based research partnerships and engagement of communities on research teams. The projects are being funded through the Community Partnership Development competitive funding opportunity, a pilot initiative from Alaska Sea Grant providing resources to build partnership capacity for research.

“A commonly identified barrier to conducting community-engaged research is accessing funding for researchers and community members to build relationships which could lead to grant opportunities,” said Molly Cain, Alaska Sea Grant’s associate director for research.

The new projects begin this fall with the goal of preparing community-academic teams to collaborate on the design of research projects related to improving understanding and management of Alaska’s coastal, marine, and watershed resources.

Areas of interest include effects of beaver expansion on fish in the Arctic, genetic approaches for monitoring salmon, linking fisheries heritage research to pathways for sustainable fishing, and landslide hazard monitoring. Project participants include University of Alaska Fairbanks, Chilkat Indian Village, Project Kutí, Alaska EPSCoR, Chignik Intertribal Coalition, Alutiiq Tribe of Old Harbor, and more. ■



ENERGY RESILIENCE INITIATIVE LAUNCHED IN YUKON-KUSKOKWIM DELTA

A new energy resilience initiative is underway in Western Alaska, led by Alaska Sea Grant. The initiative focuses on advancing energy security, affordability, and resilience in the Yukon-Kuskokwim Delta (Y-K Delta) through the *Climate Ready Workforce for Coastal Alaska* project, developing a rural energy workforce strategy tailored to the region's unique needs.

“There are a lot of energy infrastructure projects underway for rural and isolated communities in Alaska aiming to harness renewable energy resources such as wind and solar,” noted Sean Kelly, Climate Adaptation Specialist with Alaska Sea Grant. “The long-term success of these projects hinges on how well community-level energy champions are supported and place-based energy education and training for local workforces are prioritized.”

In February 2024, during the Alaska Forum on the Environment, Alaska Sea Grant brought together key figures in energy education and training, including Chris McConnell, director of the Alaska Network of Energy Education and Employment, Amanda Garvey of Sunstone Electric Company, and Annalise Klein of the Alaska Center for Energy and Power. Their discussions highlighted the critical barriers faced by rural Alaskan communities, while fostering partnerships between the organizations.

Through a series of semi-structured interviews with various state-wide and regional energy researchers, professionals, and practitioners, and site visits to assess local infrastructure, the initiative identified significant gaps and opportunities for improvement. Each conversation deepens the commitment to empowering communities, ensuring they have the skills to manage their own energy resources. Through this project and the work of several collaborators, the Y-K Delta is on the path to becoming a model of energy independence and resilience. ■





FOSTERING LOCAL RESILIENCE FOR FISHING COMMUNITIES

Climate change has dramatically impacted Gulf of Alaska fisheries. The global phenomenon has led to fisheries disasters over the last several years, including declines in Chinook and other salmon. Fishery losses may be devastating for local economies that lack economic diversity, maintain fishing-dependent food systems, and have multi-generational cultural fishing practices that cannot be replaced.

“Every fishing boat is a business, often a family business. Stress to the fishery will impact business decisions and trickle down to households,” explained fisheries anthropologist Davin Holen, the coastal community resilience specialist with Alaska Sea Grant.

To address these challenges, Alaska Sea Grant is collaborating on the grassroots project *Advancing Understanding of Climate Adaptation and Resilience in the Gulf of Alaska Fishing Communities*, organized by Marysia Szymkowiak at the NOAA Alaska Fisheries Science Center. This initiative helps communities in Sitka, Kodiak, and Cordova assess their vulnerabilities and plan for climate scenarios through participatory workshops.

These workshops stand out for being led by local organizations deeply familiar with their communities and fisheries. Preliminary sessions have already taken place in Sitka, guided by the Alaska Sustainable Fisheries Trust, and in Kodiak, organized by the Alaska Marine Conservation Council. A workshop in Cordova is currently in the planning stages, and will be led by the Prince William Sound Science Center. ■



ENVIRONMENTAL LITERACY AND WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT





YOUTH NATURE PROGRAM CONTINUES GROWTH

Now in its third year, the Coastal Connection Camps program provides educational summer activities for middle school students in Valdez and Seward, while training teachers and leaders for future camps. The program includes exploring the coastal environment, hands-on science, art, team building, and developing personal resilience.

“Parents in both communities have been thrilled that there is something productive and supervised for their kids to participate in over the summer,” said Leigh Lubin, educational specialist for Alaska Sea Grant and the camp’s architect.

Designed as a “camp-in-a-box,” the program equips leaders with the supplies needed to host camps in remote areas otherwise lacking the infrastructure to do so. This year, the Kenai Mountains-Turnagain Arm (KMTA) National Heritage Area trained 10 educators at a four-day workshop in Seward. Participating organizations included the Prince William Sound Science Center and the Alaska SeaLife Center, both of which plan to incorporate aspects of the camps into their summer programs.



The Coastal Connection Camps have grown more than seven-fold, from serving seven children in 2022, to 50 children this summer across both communities. The National Park Service is now providing five years of funding to support the KMTA National Heritage Area in running the Coastal Connections program. This vital support will enhance the program’s reach and engagement, allowing more coastal Alaskan youth to cultivate foundational awareness and skills related to their local environment.

With additional support from various partners, including the City of Valdez, the program aims to expand by offering Reconnection Camps for returning students, and counselor-in-training for high school youth. ■



SUPPORTING ALASKAN FISHERMEN IN TRAINING

Alaska Sea Grant offers fishery-related training programs to empower current and next generation of commercial fishermen. One such training combines classroom instruction with hands-on practice to provide U.S. Coast Guard-accepted two-year safety certification. Participants learn essential skills to respond to common injuries such as burns, broken bones, and hypothermia, using real-life scenarios from marine vessels.

In 2023, Alaska Sea Grant and its partners received over \$240,000 from NOAA Sea Grant for the *AK On-Board: Young Fishermen Training and Apprenticeship Program*. This two-year initiative draws on the strengths of each partner to assist with crew training, apprenticeships, and network-building.

“We’ve been working to train young fishermen in various ways for a while now,” said Gabe Dunham, Alaska Sea Grant Marine Advisory Program leader. “This project will help us put all the pieces together for a truly impactful training program.”

To engage high school students, Alaska Sea Grant, in collaboration with the Bristol Bay Regional Career and Technical Education program, introduced a two-week intensive course covering fishing gear, vessel maintenance, safety training, marine first aid, and business planning. Providing fisheries education in Bristol Bay is crucial for empowering local and Indigenous youth, ensuring they understand that this is their fishery and equipping them to invest in this vital industry.

Additionally, Alaska Sea Grant hosted a three-day workshop on oyster hatchery operations at the OceansAlaska Shellfish Hatchery, bringing together trainees and experts to advance aquaculture education and sustainable resource management. They also offered online classes in seafood direct marketing, responding to current market conditions and helping more than 40 participants explore new avenues for bringing their seafood to consumers. ■





CELEBRATING THE 10TH ANNIVERSARY OF THE ALASKA SEA GRANT STATE FELLOWSHIP

Celebrating its 10th year, the Alaska Sea Grant State Fellowship program offers a unique opportunity for early career professionals interested in the science and policy necessary for maintaining healthy marine, coastal, and watershed resources. Modeled after the successful Knauss Marine Policy Fellowship, this program offers hands-on experience in planning and implementing marine resource policies in Alaska.

The fellowship pairs students and recent graduates with host organizations or agencies in Alaska for a 12-month paid position. Past and present hosts include NOAA Fisheries Protected Resource Division, the Central Council of the Tlingit & Haida Indian Tribes of Alaska, and U.S. Geological Survey Alaska Science Center, among others.

This program supports workforce development of Alaska's emerging marine and coastal professionals, helping to launch impactful careers. With over 50 alumni, the program has grown from two fellows in its inaugural year to a cohort of 17 in 2024. The program continues to nurture a new generation of leaders dedicated to Alaska's marine resources. ■



ALASKA SEA GRANT STATE FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM

Class of 2024



Jake Cohen
*Alaska Sea Grant,
Coastal Community
Resilience Program*



Michelle Dutro
*NOAA Fisheries
Protected Resources
Division*



Rachel French
*Alaska Sea Grant,
Mariculture*



Maddie McArthur
*UAF Institute of
Northern Engineering*



Mack Hughes
*U.S. Geological
Survey, Alaska Science
Center*



Jenna Kennedy
*Alaska Mariculture
Alliance*



Phoebe Koenig
Southeast Conference



Angela Korabik
*NOAA Fisheries,
Alaska Fisheries
Science Center*



Noah Meyer
*Central Council of
the Tlingit & Haida
Indian Tribes of Alaska*



Addie Norgaard
*UAF Alaska Center
for Energy and Power*



Alaina Plauché
*North Pacific Fishery
Management Council*



Krystal Renta
*NOAA Fisheries, Alaska
Fisheries Science Center*



Emily Reynolds
*NOAA Fisheries,
Alaska Aquaculture
Program*



Alyssa Sanchez
*NOAA Fisheries,
Habitat Conservation
Division*



Jenna Schlener
*U.S. Geological
Survey, Alaska Science
Center*



**Alice Van
Veenendaal**
*Alaska Sea Grant,
Communications*



Devanie White
*NOAA Fisheries,
Sustainable Fisheries
Division*



ALASKA SEA GRANT
**State
Fellowship**
PROGRAM

TWO ALASKA SEA GRANT NOMINEES SELECTED AS KNAUSS FELLOWS



Kit Cunningham



Nick Mills

Two Alaska students were selected for the 2024 Sea Grant Knauss Marine Policy Fellowship program, one of the most prestigious marine policy fellowships in the country. Kit Cunningham and Nick Mills were chosen after being nominated for the positions by Alaska Sea Grant. They joined a class of 85 early career professionals from across the country to spend a year working with the government in Washington, D.C., on marine and coastal science, public administration, and policy issues.

Cunningham, a graduate student at the University of Alaska Fairbanks and employee for the Alaska Department of Fish and Game, was selected to join the legislative branch in U.S. Senator Lisa Murkowski's office. Cunningham emphasized that systemic change requires more than science alone, so she pursued the Knauss Fellowship in order to gain tools for creating legislation that instigates immediate action regarding marine conservation.

Mills earned a bachelor's degree in wildlife biology and a master's degree in public administration from the University of Montana. He was placed into the Office of the Assistant Secretary for Fish and Wildlife and Parks at the U.S. Department of the Interior. Mills' long-term goal is to advance as a policymaker and diver in a leadership role in the western United States.

"When it comes to natural resource management and conservation policy, I've embraced my role as a generalist," says Mills. He points to the long-lasting benefit of consensus-driven policy as a takeaway from the Knauss Fellowship. ■

SUPPORTING UNDERGRADUATE STUDENTS THROUGH THE COMMUNITY-ENGAGED FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM

Alaska Sea Grant welcomed its fourth cohort of Community-Engaged Fellows. This summer, five undergraduate students are working on projects that connect science with coastal communities through collaboration.

“The fellows in the 2024 CEF cohort are an inspiring group,” said Brooke Carney, deputy director of Alaska Sea Grant. “They each have unique backgrounds and embody our mission to center the needs and interests of coastal communities.”

The fellows attended a two-day retreat in Anchorage focused on professional development and team building. They explored career pathways with former fellows, and engaged in outdoor activities like rafting and biking. University of Alaska Anchorage professor Amy Bishop presented to the group and discussed food security in rural coastal communities and facilitated conversations on community engagement.

The Alaska Sea Grant Community-Engaged Fellowship is part of a national initiative by the Sea Grant network, aimed at increasing representation in the coastal sciences. The program emphasizes community involvement, mentorship, cohort building, and developing professional skills. ■



2024 CEF cohort: (back) Nels Ure, Brendan Hegarty
(front) Joi Gross, Leyla Thompson, Mary Simeon





ALASKA SEA GRANT RESEARCH TRAINEES

Dana Bloch MS oceanography
Southeast Alaska trolling vessel ocean measurement program

Maeghan Connor MS wildlife biology and conservation
Integrating emerging technologies with community-based observations to assess spotted seal ecology at terrestrial haul-outs in Arctic Alaska

Muriel Dittrich MS marine biology
Development of cultivation protocols for the red seaweed, dulse, to support traditional food systems in Southeast Alaska

Elena Eberhardt MS fisheries
Quantifying the influence of environmental conditions on potential trophic interactions and growth of juvenile sockeye salmon and threespine stickleback within Iliamna Lake

Sof Fox MS fisheries
Evolutionary underpinnings of stress response in Pacific oysters

Elizabeth Mik'aq Lindley PhD fisheries
Pink Arctic: patterns, processes, and consequences of increasing Pacific salmon in the high north

Riley O'Neil MS marine biology
Do mariculture farms improve habitat for sea otter prey?

George Payne MS civil engineering
Nature-based and community-engaged Arctic coastal protection

Ben Peterson MS biology
Too big to ignore: Foraging strategies and competition between marine top predators in a rapidly changing Bering Sea

Emily Reynolds MS marine biology
The relationship between oyster farms and their environment, a sea otter's perspective

Zach Stamplis MS fisheries
A transformative approach to rapidly assess critical life history and energetic responses of fish to environmental change

Student selection in progress
Development of a non-lethal genetic-based method for aging Pacific halibut

ALASKA SEA GRANT FACULTY AND STAFF



Ginny Eckert
Director, Juneau



Tav Ammu
Marine Advisory Agent, Dillingham



Molly Cain
Associate Director for Research, Fairbanks



Brooke Carney
Deputy Director, Anchorage



James Crimp
Shellfish Mariculture Specialist, Juneau



Gabe Dunham
MAP Leader and Fisheries Specialist, Juneau



Ashley Dunker
Program and Event Coordinator, Kodiak



Quentin Fong
Seafood Marketing Specialist, Kodiak



Melissa Good
Mariculture Specialist, KSMSC coordinator, Kodiak



Davin Holen
Coastal Community Resilience Specialist, Anchorage



Trinda Huffman
Administrative Assistant, Anchorage



Arron Jones
Mariculture Technician, Kodiak



Sean Kelly
Climate Adaptation Specialist, Anchorage



Leigh Lubin
Marine Education Specialist, Valdez



Julie Matweyou
Marine Advisory Agent, Kodiak



Dawn Montano
Communications Project Manager, Fairbanks



Julie Parshall
Program Administrator, Fairbanks



Dave Partee
Technology and Communications, Fairbanks



Sunny Rice
Marine Advisory Agent, Petersburg



Chris Sannito
Seafood Technology Specialist, Kodiak



Marc Solano
Seafood Processing Workforce Development Coordinator, Kodiak



Gay Sheffield
Marine Advisory Agent, Nome



John Williams
Fisheries Workforce Specialist, Cordova



ALASKA SEA GRANT ADVISORY COMMITTEE

Jodie Anderson, Director
UAF Institute of Agriculture,
Natural Resources and Extension

Kaja Brix, Arctic Program Director
NOAA Fisheries Alaska Region

Diana Evans, Deputy Director
North Pacific Fishery Management Council

Nicole Kimball, Vice President
Pacific Seafood Processors Association

Michael Kohan, (*Chair*) Science and Policy Director
Sitka Salmon Shares

Jon Kurland, Alaska Regional Administrator
NOAA National Marine Fisheries Service

Scott Lindsey, Regional Director
NOAA National Weather Service

Angela Lunda, Assistant Professor of Education
University of Alaska Southeast

Vera Metcalf, Director
Eskimo Walrus Commission at Kawerak, Inc.

Hazel Nelson, Board of Directors
Bristol Bay Native Corporation

Aaron Poe, Network Program Officer
Alaska Conservation Foundation

Dave Reggiani, Aquaculture Expert
Prince William Sound Aquaculture Corporation

Chris Siddon, Marine Fisheries Scientist
Alaska Department of Fish and Game

Wanda Wahl, Director*
UAF Bristol Bay Campus

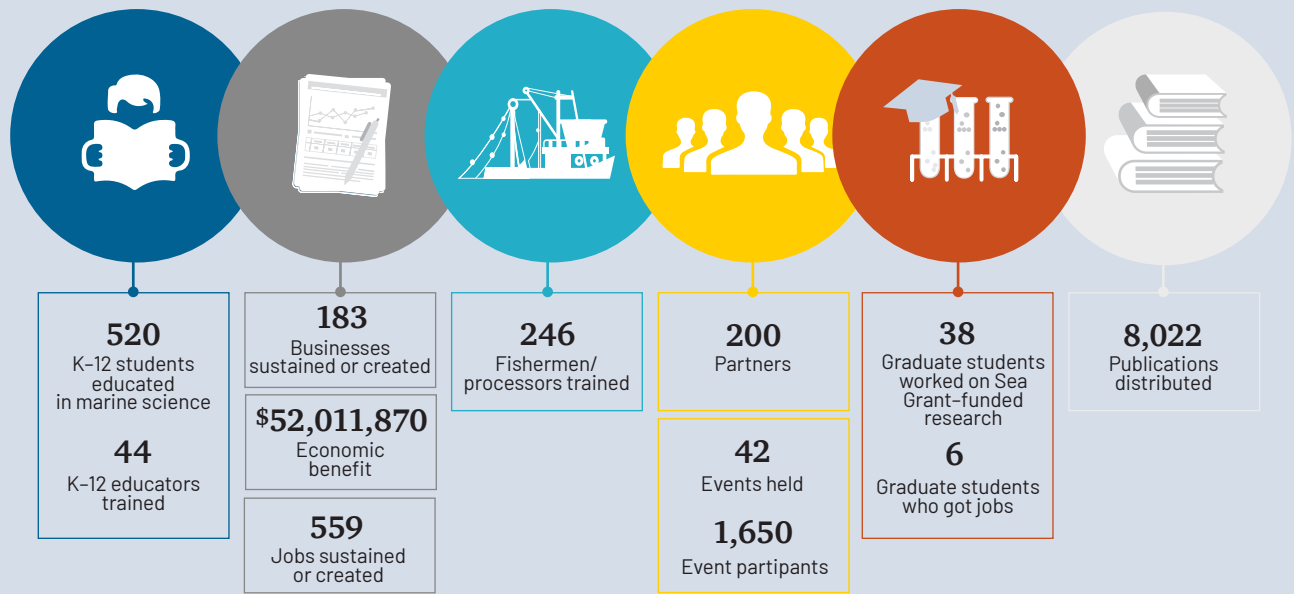
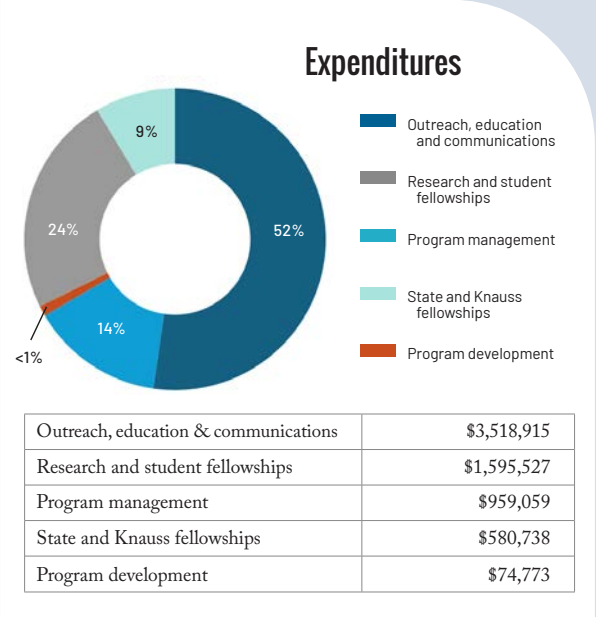
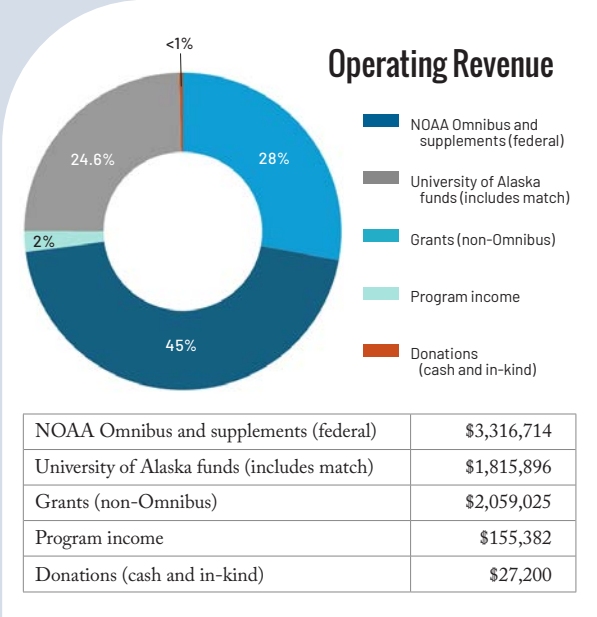
Dee Williams, (*Vice-chair*) Deputy Regional Director
US Geological Survey

Sheyna Wisdom, Executive Director
Alaska Ocean Observing System

**Joined fall 2024*

ALASKA SEA GRANT BY THE NUMBERS

Reporting data represents activities Feb. 1, 2023, to Jan. 31, 2024, which aligns with the National Sea Grant College Program's reporting cycle.






Sea Grant
ALASKA

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ALASKA
FAIRBANKS

